



The Lagoon Nebula

The bright, star-forming Lagoon Nebula (M8, NGC6523) is some 5,200 light-years away, within the archer's bow of the constellation of Sagittarius. It is visible to the naked eye in a rural sky and is a good binocular object. Binoculars will reveal the cluster of stars, NGC 6530, within the nebula.

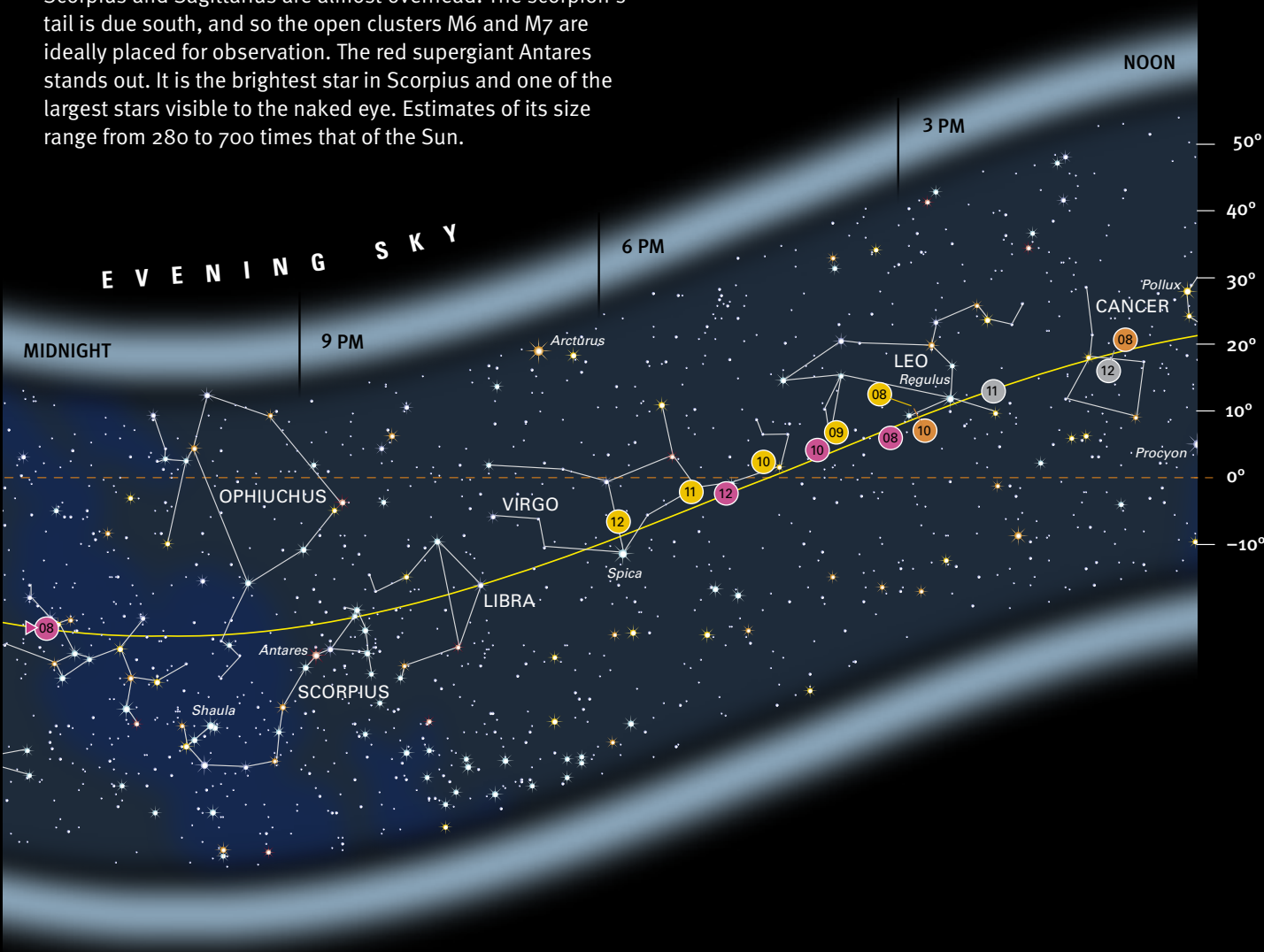
The view toward Sagittarius is toward the center of our galaxy. A large and bright field of stars, M24 in Sagittarius is visible to the naked eye; so is the Lagoon Nebula (M8). M22, the third-brightest globular cluster, is also in Sagittarius. Easy to find with binoculars, it can also be seen by sharp-eyed observers in a rural sky. A group of eight stars to pick out in this star-studded part of the sky. The arc of stars at the forefeet of Sagittarius is easier to see. It is Corona Australis, the Southern Crown, and one of the smallest constellations of all.

Looking north, Ophiuchus is high in the sky; below it is the figure of Hercules. Vega in Lyra is close to the horizon. Adjoining Vega is the northern-hemisphere constellation Cygnus. Observers to the north of about 30°S are able to see the complete figure of the flying swan. Above it in the northeastern sky is Aquila, the eagle.

The Delta Aquarid meteor shower reaches its peak around the 29th of this month. Up to 20 rather faint meteors an hour radiate from the southern half of Aquarius.

■ SOUTHERN LATITUDES

Scorpius and Sagittarius are almost overhead. The scorpion's tail is due south, and so the open clusters M6 and M7 are ideally placed for observation. The red supergiant Antares stands out. It is the brightest star in Scorpius and one of the largest stars visible to the naked eye. Estimates of its size range from 280 to 700 times that of the Sun.



Ophiuchus

The serpent-holder Ophiuchus is the 11th-largest constellation, lying on the edge of the Milky Way's starry path. The figure is seen here, head high. Within his body are two globular clusters, M10 and M12—both are visible through binoculars.